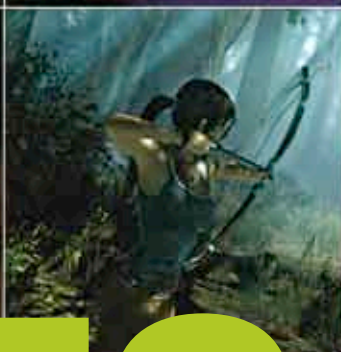
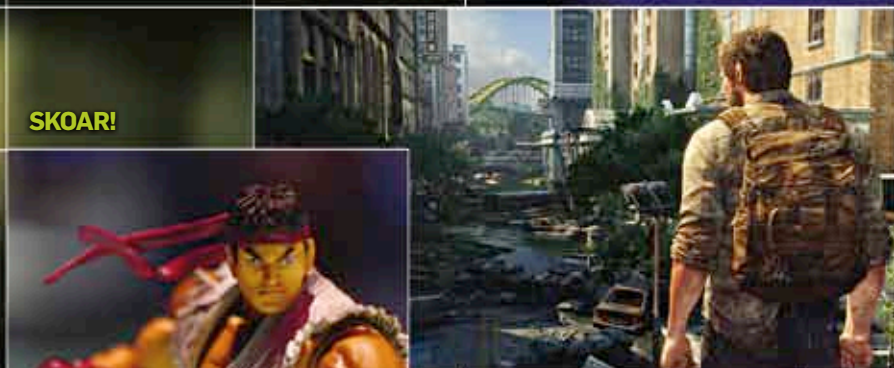


SKOAR!

PHOTOS: SETH COLLINS



Live from E3

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Typically the last year in a console's life cycle causes a lull at E3; less excitement, fewer games. The console publishers are hard at work on their new systems and most publishers are working on new games that they can't unveil until the new consoles have been officially announced. This was certainly the case at E3 2012, and the reaction from the crowd made it obvious.

Beginning with the press conferences the day before the show opened, the press seemed disappointed. A few games were shown and advertised as being "new technology" but none were interactive. However, while it was certainly a down year for console gaming, PC games took center stage. While many games shown were multiplatform and will be available for PCs, Xbox 360, and PlayStation 3, it is clear that PC is now the lead platform and developers were choosing that version to display at the show. So, what stood out on the PC front? It all starts with SimCity. Developed once

again by Maxis and expected to release sometime in 2012, the game looks incredible and the entire demo just felt so charming. Depth of field and day and night cycles are used to bring life to the game graphically, with small details here and there that are sure to impress. This time the game is so full of little details – seeing housing being built, citizens move in, or houses going up for sale. The game feels more alive than ever before, without coming off as a merging of SimCity with The Sims. If we had to choose only one, this would be THE game of the show.

Borderlands 2 from Gearbox was also impressive. Fans of the original game can expect more of the same, which is nothing to complain about. The original was great. The graphics look considerably better, and it appears the game play has been refined without changing too much of what people loved. It's basically like taking the original Borderlands and amping it up several levels. The key design concept of Borderlands 2 seems to be more guns (in excess of one million of them), more excitement, and more mayhem.

While Assassin's Creed as a series has become stale, the developers seemed

to have taken great care with Assassin's Creed III and made it something just a bit different; enough to grab our attention at the show. This time the game is set during the American Revolution. Fans of platform games will be excited by the ability to run, jump and climb through trees and cliffs. The combat system has been renovated and is now more offensive, less defensive. Perhaps most importantly is the new inclusion of naval battles, which brings an entirely new aspect to the game and looked visually appealing and fun.

The new Tomb Raider from Square Enix was another game looking to take a longstanding series in a slightly new direction. All of the key pieces were in place – graphics looked great, the game play was fun, and the heritage here can't be questioned. The real change is in direction, with the developers looking to shift Lara Croft from almost supernatural heroine to something more vulnerable and engaging. To do so they are setting this game earlier than any in the series. It chronicles what appears to be Lara's first adventure, in which she is less in control, more an unwilling victim of circumstance than a willing adventurer.